

The Clockwork Garden

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — Petals of Brass

Morning light dripped through the skylight and landed on gears disguised as daisies. Alana knelt beside a rose whose petals chimed the hour — soft bronze notes that made SPARK tilt his head like a conductor hearing the first bar of a symphony he had not yet catalogued.

Maya traced the stem with one finger, careful not to snag her sleeve on the copper thorns. "Someone built a garden that tells time."

"Someone built a garden that keeps secrets," Natalia said, reading the inscription etched on a leaf: When all twelve bloom as one, the heart door opens.

The clockwork garden occupied a walled courtyard the labyrinth had hidden behind a biography section, behind a shelf about explorers who never came home, and behind a door that only appeared if you were reading with your whole body instead of just your eyes. Vines of copper wire climbed trellises shaped like ivy. Bees of painted tin hovered without buzzing. Everything ticked — not loudly, but with the patient, steady rhythm of a pocket watch dreaming it was a forest.

Alana opened her toolkit — a leather roll with twenty loops for twenty tools — and set it on the mossy flagstones. "If it's machinery, it has a logic. If it has logic, I can map it."

"If it has secrets, we can annoy them until they reveal themselves," Maya added helpfully.

SPARK projected a glowing diagram onto the nearest trellis. "Twelve flower units detected. Current bloom status: seven of twelve active. Inactive units show no damage signature. Estimated time to full bloom: unknown."

"Unknown is your least useful setting," Alana told him.

"Unknown is my most honest setting," he replied, and tilted his sensor the way a good scientist admits a gap.

Natalia cupped a brass tulip that opened when she breathed on it, responding to warmth the way real flowers respond to sun. Inside the cup sat a seed of polished gold, no bigger than a lentil, engraved with a single word too small to read without squinting: Yet.

"Souvenir or clue?" she asked.

"Both," Alana said. "Always both in here."

She began sketching the courtyard on graph paper, labeling each flower unit with a number and a question mark. Maya counted petal chimes. SPARK recorded everything. Natalia kept the gold seed in her palm, waiting to learn what yet would mean.

Chapter 2 — The Gardener's Riddle

They found the gardener at noon — or the labyrinth's idea of noon, when light pooled on the central sundial and

made the shadow spell MAYA. Maya stared at it for a long time.

"Is it pointing at me, or warning me?" she asked.

"Probably both," Natalia said, which Maya considered perfectly fair.

The gardener was a statue that moved when you weren't looking directly at it: a woman of ceramic and clock springs, apron hung with tiny wrenches no bigger than a little finger, hair coiled in a bun held together by actual springs. She had a kind face, the way kind faces look when they have been patient a very long time and are not angry about it.

She handed Natalia a card engraved with silver letters:

I have twelve faces but one voice, I bloom without soil and tick without choice. What am I?

"The garden," Natalia said without hesitation.

The statue nodded — the slow, satisfied kind of nod that teachers give when a student finally finds the answer they had been holding cupped in their hands all along. She handed Natalia a second card:

Correct. Now fix what pride broke.

"Pride broke something?" Maya repeated. "That's dramatic even for this place."

They searched the courtyard in widening circles — Alana checking the structural columns, Maya inspecting the flower beds, Natalia reading the fine print at the base of every plinth. SPARK scanned for heat signatures and magnetic anomalies. It was Alana who found it, in the end: a cracked mainspring beneath the central fountain, a coil of steel large as a hula hoop, snapped clean through at one end, curled in on itself like something that had been under too much pressure for too long and had finally let go.

"This is precision work," Alana said, crouching to examine the break. "We need the right alloy. We need a forge."

SPARK's scanner whirled. "Historical note: the original spring was forged from gratitude and recycled telescope parts. Modern metallurgy does not classify gratitude as an alloy."

"Gratitude isn't a metal," Maya said.

"Everything is a metal if you're brave enough," Alana replied, which was not accurate science but was, most definitely, excellent attitude.

She closed her toolkit and looked at her sisters. Neither of them stepped back.

Chapter 3 — Gears and Apologies

The sisters split tasks the way they always did — not because anyone ordered them to, not because a chart on a

wall said so, but because each of them had a superpower and they had all learned the hard way that superpowers work better when you aim them in different directions.

Maya talked to the flowers. It was not as silly as it sounded, because the flowers had mechanisms sensitive to vibration, and Maya's voice had the particular frequency of someone who meant what she said. She discovered they opened faster when she told them honest stories about her day — especially the parts where she had been wrong and said sorry. A copper iris opened three centimeters when she apologized for leaving her library book in the rain. A bronze foxglove unfolded completely when she admitted she had blamed Natalia for losing a puzzle piece that Maya had actually hidden in her sock drawer.

Natalia read old gardener logs in the labyrinth archive — six leather journals shelved between a history of lighthouses and a manual for repairing astrolabes. The journals smelled like rain and iron. The handwriting was careful until it wasn't. The last entry, three pages before a section left permanently blank, said: I refused help. The spring broke under the weight of my certainty. I do not know how to ask for what I do not know how to accept.

Alana melted broken gears in a tiny forge the statue gardener revealed beneath a stepping stone when Alana said thank you to it, just to be polite. SPARK fed her temperature ratios and alloy compositions. Together, over four hours of careful work, they shaped a new coil — thinner in the middle than the original, stronger at the reinforced ends, with a texture like a fingerprint because Alana had pressed her thumb into the cooling metal on purpose.

"It's not perfect," she warned.

"Perfect broke last time," Natalia said. "Let's try humble."

They installed the spring at dusk, fitting the ends into their housings and tightening the anchor bolts while the courtyard dimmed around them. The fountain shuddered. Stopped. Ticked once, like a heart after a long rest. Then it found its rhythm — a steady, generous pulse — and one by one, the remaining five flowers bloomed. Chimes layered into a chord that climbed the walls and made the copper vines vibrate like a plucked string.

The heart door outlined itself in gold light beneath the fountain's basin.

"We didn't open it yet," Maya whispered.

"We earned the option," Natalia said. "That's a different thing."

Chapter 4 — Beneath the Reading Nook

The heart door was not a door in the ordinary sense. It was a panel of interlocked gear-petals that folded back when Alana turned a small handle shaped like a daisy stem. Beneath it lay a spiral staircase lined with pressed flowers under glass — delphiniums and sweet peas and marigolds so perfectly preserved they looked painted. Each step chimed a different month when you stood on it. January was a clean silver note. June was warm as a window at noon. December, Natalia's favorite, rang soft and snowy, like a bell heard from very far away.

At the bottom of the stair lay a room the size of the library's coziest reading nook, but perfectly round, with curved shelves rising to a ceiling of hammered copper tiles. The shelves held seed packets labeled not with plant

names but with feelings: Curiosity. Patience. Joyful Stubbornness. Willingness to Be Wrong. The Kind of Tired That Feels Like Accomplishment.

In the center of the room, on a table built from a single slice of an ancient oak, sat a book bound in living moss that was still growing. New green tips curled at the corners. Its title, pressed in silver letters into the front cover, read: The Clockwork Garden — Maintenance for Keepers.

"We're keepers now?" Maya asked.

"We're readers who didn't run away when things got complicated," Alana said. "Same job, different setting."

They read the first duty aloud together, each taking a word: Water with attention. Prune with honesty. Allow visitors. Accept help before things break.

Natalia ran her finger across that last line twice.

SPARK added a footer to his working memory. "New responsibility acquired. Recommend celebratory snack." He produced four small wrapped chocolates from a compartment in his side panel that none of them had known existed. When Alana asked how long he had been carrying them, he said, "Since I first detected this garden might be something worth celebrating."

They ate the chocolates on the staircase, one step each, and the December chime rang twice without anyone stepping on it.

Back in the courtyard, stars had appeared in the skylight glass — not reflected stars, but actual distant lights, as if the labyrinth had quietly borrowed a corner of night while they were underground. The statue gardener was gone, replaced by a small brass plaque: Thank you for accepting help.

Maya saluted the plaque. "You're welcome, ceramic lady."

The garden ticked on around them, keeping time for things still growing.

Chapter 5 — The Bloom That Wasn't on the Map

A thirteenth flower appeared the next morning, in the hour just after the labyrinth unlocked but before any visitors arrived. It was silver — not polished silver, but the soft silver of old mirrors and well-loved spoons — and it was tucked in the gap behind the fountain where no one had thought to look because Alana's diagram accounted for exactly twelve flower positions and twelve was the number the garden had declared.

It did not chime. It did not tick. It simply stood very still and listened.

Natalia found it by accident, reaching behind the fountain to retrieve a dropped pencil. The silver petals were cupped upward, like hands waiting to receive something.

She sat cross-legged in front of it for twenty minutes while Alana updated mechanical schematics and Maya

practiced names for the tin bees. Slowly, quietly, Natalia began to speak into the flower's cup. She told it about the school week where she had been invisible to her friends but hadn't said so. She told it about being the middle sister, about how she was old enough to help but young enough to still need help, and how that made her feel like two different people sharing one pair of shoes. She told it about keys and doors and whether she was brave or just curious, and whether being brave required that you knew the difference.

The flower stored her words as dew that gathered in the cup's center. By afternoon, that dew had become a tiny mirror — no bigger than a bottle cap — and in the mirror, Natalia saw small moments she had not thought anyone was watching: herself helping Maya tie her shoes before a school run. Herself talking Alana through a maths problem at the kitchen table in a calm voice, even though Alana had been frustrated. Herself sitting with SPARK when his battery ran low, reading to him so he wouldn't have to process in the dark.

"Self-portraits are cheating," Maya said from behind her, but gently, with the voice she saved for things she actually found remarkable.

"Self-recognition isn't," Natalia replied.

They agreed the thirteenth flower was the garden's way of saying that some blooms do not count toward riddles, because they grow for one person at a time and cannot be hurried.

Alana updated her map in permanent ink, adding the thirteenth position. Then she added a pencil note in the corner: Room for surprises.

SPARK flagged the update as excellent scientific practice and filed it accordingly.

Chapter 6 — Visitors at the Gate

Children from the neighborhood began finding the clockwork courtyard the week after the mainspring was fixed — not many, and never in crowds, but one at a time, each drawn by a different chime that only their particular ears could hear. A girl who loved puzzles heard the bronze rose spelling coordinates. A boy who disliked reading heard the brass daisies tapping his name in a patient, unhurried rhythm. A pair of twins heard a duet and arrived together, which had never happened before, and SPARK logged it as a statistical anomaly worth studying.

The labyrinth, it seemed, had always intended an audience beyond the Allen girls. It had simply been waiting for the garden to be working properly before it sent out invitations.

Natalia became the tour guide, because she had read the maintenance manual three times through and knew which flowers bloomed for honesty and which ones needed you to say something aloud that you had been carrying privately. She also had a calm voice that made the garden tick a little more evenly.

Maya became the official joke teller, which served a purpose beyond comedy: nervous visitors laughed, and when they laughed their shoulders came down from their ears, and when their shoulders came down they could hear the chimes properly. SPARK confirmed this as a documented phenomenon in several acoustic research papers. He cited them, which Maya found both unnecessary and very SPARK.

Alana became the safety officer, with a whistle shaped like a tulip that she had tooled herself from a leftover gear housing. She had a list of rules she enforced mildly: no pulling petals, no leaning into the fountain, no asking SPARK to do your homework while you looked at flowers.

SPARK handed out translated labels — index cards in neat handwriting — for the flowers that ticked in Morse code, because he had decided the messages were too good to remain encrypted.

A boy who hated reading sat beside the brass daisies for a whole afternoon and discovered that the ticks spelled his name, then his favorite color, then a sentence about his grandmother that only he could have known. He came back the next day with a notebook. He came back the day after that with a question.

"The garden grows readers," the Keeper said from the stone archway, watching.

"The garden grows people," Natalia corrected, without looking up from the visitor's notebook she was annotating. "Readers are just people who are practicing paying attention."

The Keeper was quiet for a long moment.

"Yes," he said. "That's better."

The heart door stayed open a crack after that — an invitation, not a secret.

Chapter 7 — The Tin Bees' Secret

The tin bees had always been there, hovering at the level of the copper vines in their painted-on stillness, and most visitors walked past them without a second thought. They looked decorative. They looked like the kind of charming detail a craftsperson adds at the end, when everything else is finished and there is still a little warmth left over.

Maya did not walk past them.

She had been watching the bees since their first day in the garden, noting the slight vibration in their wings, the way they shifted position by a centimeter or two between visits — which she had confirmed by marking tiny chalk lines on the trellis at each bee's position. When she mentioned this to Alana, Alana produced a magnifying loupe from her toolkit and confirmed that each bee's body was a hinged capsule with a lid no wider than a fingernail.

They opened three bees over the course of a careful afternoon. Each one contained a different thing: a folded paper with a paragraph of handwritten text. SPARK identified the writing as prose — specifically, short stories, each exactly nine sentences long.

"The bees are books," Maya said, sitting back on her heels.

"Folded small," SPARK confirmed. "There are forty-seven bees in the garden. That is forty-seven stories."

They gathered the stories gently, reading each one before returning the bee to its position on the trellis. The stories were about the kinds of moments that don't make it into histories: the day a girl learned to whistle, and the afternoon she taught her brother; a morning when a bridge was built by strangers who never met and never knew they had helped each other; an evening when a library caught the smell of the ocean and kept it for three days before letting it go. Small stories. True-feeling stories. Stories about the weight of ordinary things that turned out to matter enormously.

Natalia read them in order. Maya read her favorites twice. Alana sorted them by theme on the reading table they had set up in the courtyard: Discovery. Loss. Returning. Beginning Again.

"Someone wrote all of these," Natalia said. "Someone loved all of these moments enough to fold them up and put them inside bees."

"The maintenance manual mentions it," SPARK said. "Chapter eleven. Title: Stories Too Small for Shelves."

Natalia added a new rule to the keeper's log that evening: Every garden needs a place for small things. Bees are good. Pockets are also good. The important thing is that small things do not get left behind.

She pressed her thumb to the page to sign it, the way keepers do when they mean it.

Chapter 8 — A Seed for Sorrow

It was Maya who first found the locked packet.

The seed shelves in the round room beneath the reading nook held dozens of packets in neat rows, each labeled with feelings — Patience, Curiosity, Willingness to Be Wrong — but one was set apart on a high shelf in a small lacquered box with a brass clasp that required four steps to open: lift, turn, press, breathe. The breathe step was the most important and also the hardest, because it required you to stop hurrying.

The label inside the box read: Sorrow, unshared.

Maya did not touch the packet. She called her sisters.

They sat in the round room together and looked at it on the table between them. None of them reached for it immediately, and that, SPARK noted privately, was itself a kind of wisdom — the kind that doesn't announce itself.

"It's a seed," Alana said finally. "Seeds are for planting."

"But what grows from it?" Maya asked.

Natalia thought for a long time, long enough for a new green tip to uncurl from the corner of the moss book and then slowly curl again, deciding it wasn't quite the moment yet.

"I think sorrow that's shared changes," she said. "It doesn't stop being sorrow. But it stops being only yours."

They took the packet upstairs to the garden and looked for the right place. The garden suggested its own answer — near the thirteenth flower, in the soft earth beside the fountain where the clay was dark and damp, where something had been waiting for company. They planted it together, each of them pressing the soil down in turn, and Maya told the soil something true about a day she had been sadder than she'd admitted to anyone, in the way she had learned flowers opened for honesty.

Nothing grew immediately. They hadn't expected it to.

But the next morning, a small plant had pushed up beside the thirteenth flower — no petals yet, just leaves of deep green edged in silver, with a texture like old velvet. It didn't tick. It didn't chime. It breathed instead — in and out, slowly, the way something does when it is held in company instead of alone.

SPARK updated his records: "Thirteenth flower companion plant logged. Classification: Shared sorrow, in the process of becoming something else."

Natalia read that note back to herself three times.

"Yes," she said softly. "That's right."

Chapter 9 — The Night Garden

No one had planned to stay in the clockwork garden after dark, but the night it happened was the night a storm closed the labyrinth's upper doors and the biography aisle filled with the sound of wind that had come from somewhere very far away and seemed to have been traveling for some time.

The three sisters and SPARK waited out the storm in the courtyard, wrapped in blankets from the seed room's storage shelves — those shelves, it turned out, held far more than seeds — and watched what the garden did when it thought no one was there to observe it.

It was entirely different at night.

The copper vines glowed along their lengths with soft amber light that came from within the wire itself, as if the electricity they conducted had borrowed warmth from all the daylight it had carried. The flowers did not chime but hummed — a lower register, below hearing but felt in the chest, the way distant thunder arrives before the sound does. The tin bees, dutiful and still in daytime, moved at night in slow deliberate loops, each one circling the flowers in a pattern that SPARK logged as navigational — the bees marking a territory, then yielding it to the next bee, sharing the air the way good neighbors share a path.

The sundial, without a sun, showed stars instead — pinpoints of silver reflecting from some surface above that none of them could locate, creating a map of the sky on the sundial's face that shifted in real time as the storm moved.

"The garden has two shifts," Alana said, watching the bees and writing in her notebook. "A daytime garden for visitors and a nighttime garden for itself."

"Every place that matters has a private self," Natalia said.

Maya, who had not spoken for a while, was lying on her back on the flagstones, looking straight up through the skylight. "I think the labyrinth gets lonely sometimes," she said. "Not sad-lonely. Big-lonely. The kind where you have so much room that things echo."

No one disagreed.

SPARK dimmed his projections to the lowest useful setting, so as not to intrude on the garden's private hours. He took quiet notes and did not narrate them aloud.

When the storm passed and the upper doors unlatched with a soft click, none of them moved immediately. They stayed in the amber glow and the low hum until SPARK noted, very gently, that it was well past any reasonable bedtime and the garden's nighttime shift was entering its final hour.

They filed out slowly, stepping over the December stair without chiming it, leaving the night garden to its last few minutes of being only itself.

Chapter 10 — The Keeper's Clock

The Keeper had a clock room.

The girls discovered it not because the Keeper told them — he rarely volunteered information, offering questions instead and waiting to see which direction the searcher carried them — but because Alana, mapping the labyrinth's hidden architecture with her graph paper and her methodical patience, found a door behind the garden's maintenance cabinet labeled with a single engraved letter: K.

The room was not large. It held a worktable, a reading chair, and twenty-two clocks, each stopped at a different time. The walls were covered with pages of careful handwritten observations, each one dated.

"He has been watching this garden for years," Natalia said, reading a page near the back wall. "This entry is from before we were born."

The oldest entry she could find was forty-three years ago. It described the garden's first bloom — seven flowers on a Tuesday afternoon — and beside it the Keeper's note: Promising. Will require patience and, I suspect, better company than I have yet provided.

"He built it?" Alana asked.

"I think he tends it," SPARK said. "As a keeper tends. There may have been gardeners before him. The maintenance manual mentions a lineage."

The most recent entry was dated three days before the sisters had first found the garden. It read: The spring is broken and I am too old to forge a new one. I have left the riddle. I leave the rest to whoever is brave enough, or stubborn enough, or curious enough. Probably all three.

Maya read that entry twice, then looked at her sisters.

"He knew we were coming," she said. It was almost not a question.

"He left conditions," Natalia said. "Not a guarantee. There is a difference."

They left the room exactly as they had found it — the chair replaced, the page restored, the lamp not touched. Alana marked the room on her architectural drawing with a small K and a careful circle.

On their way out, the Keeper was in the archway again, doing what he did: watching, waiting, asking questions with his posture and his patience.

"Your clocks are all stopped," Alana said.

"I know what time it is," the Keeper said. "I don't need them for that."

"Then what do you need them for?"

He looked at the garden for a long moment before he answered.

"Remembering that I don't know everything yet."

Chapter 11 — The Gardener Returns

On the morning before their last full day with the clockwork garden, the statue gardener returned.

Not as a statue. She arrived as a woman — real and warm, with calloused hands and a bun of grey-brown hair held with actual clock springs, and an apron with actual wrenches in the pockets, each worn smooth from long use. She sat on the fountain's edge as naturally as someone who had sat there ten thousand times before, and she watched the sisters the way people watch things they built and then, painfully and correctly, let go.

Her name, she told them when Natalia asked, was Edith. She had made the clockwork garden forty years ago for reasons she had since had to revise several times, because honest reasons evolve when you keep looking at them.

"I made it because I wanted something beautiful," she said. "Then I made it because I was lonely. Then I broke it because I was proud and refused help. Then I turned myself into a statue — not literally, though close enough in practice — and stopped being useful, and waited."

"What were you waiting for?" Maya asked.

Edith looked at the thirteenth flower, which had turned its silver cup toward her the way heliotrope turns to find the sun.

"For someone to fix it without needing me to deserve it first," she said. "For someone to do the work because the garden was worth doing, not because I was worth forgiving."

She was quiet for a moment. "I see you planted something beside my listening flower."

"The seed labeled Sorrow," Natalia said. "We thought it needed company."

Edith nodded once, slowly and fully. "That is exactly the right instinct for gardening, and for most other things."

She stayed through the afternoon, working beside Alana at the maintenance table and showing her a second method for forming coil springs that distributed tension differently — more forgiving at the center. She showed Natalia the annotated sections of the maintenance manual that cross-referenced books shelved in the library above, passages that could only be understood after spending time in the garden. She and Maya counted all forty-seven bees together and confirmed each one was precisely where it should be.

When she left, near evening, she paused in the archway and asked without turning: "You'll keep the Keeper's clock room tidy?"

"Yes," Alana said.

"And the seed shelves stocked?"

"We are labeling new ones," Natalia said.

Edith smiled for the first time, and it fit her face the way a good tool fits the hand that has known it for years.

"The garden has been waiting for people like you for a very long time," she said, and walked out through the biography aisle without looking back, which is the correct way to leave something you trust completely.

Chapter 12 — Spring Forward

On the last day of their clockwork spring, all twelve flowers bloomed at once without being asked.

The chord they made — all twelve chimes striking together, layered and harmonized, each note a different month — was the sound of a library waking up, or perhaps a library remembering why it had always been awake. It rang for eleven seconds, which SPARK timed precisely, and then softened to an undertone, the kind that lives in the walls after the music is finished, in the stone and the copper and the air between things.

The sisters stood in the center of the courtyard with their hands linked — Alana on the left, Natalia in the middle, Maya on the right — and none of them said anything for a while, which was unusual and exactly right.

Alana counted the ticks to steady herself, the way she always counted when something was too large for ordinary words.

Maya named each flower quietly, one by one, in the names she had given them over the weeks: the apologetic iris, the foxglove that held patience, the rose that chimed the hour, the tulip that opened for warmth, and the thirteenth in silver at the fountain's edge, its companion plant now an inch taller and a shade greener.

Natalia opened the moss book to its final page and read the last line aloud, the line after all the duties and the cross-references and the notes from keepers past: When you leave, carry the rhythm with you. Not the garden — the rhythm. The way of paying attention. The habit of noticing small things and deciding they matter.

The Keeper stood in the archway and did not come forward. He raised one hand in the kind of wave that means I see you, not goodbye.

They walked back through the heart door, down through the December stair with its soft bell, and into the biography aisle. The courtyard door sealed quietly behind them — not locked, the moss book had been clear on this — but resting, the way a good instrument rests in the silence between performances.

In the real world, three days later, their kitchen clock stopped. Alana fixed it with a small screwdriver and a new coil she formed from memory, pressing her thumb into the cooling metal at the center the way she had learned mattered. The clock ticked. It sounded, somehow, like a garden.

The girls smiled at it across the kitchen, and the kitchen felt a little larger than it had before, the way a room does when the people in it have been somewhere worth returning from.

Somewhere beneath a labyrinth, below a reading nook, a silver flower held its cup to a fading afternoon light. Beside it, the seed of shared sorrow had grown one more centimeter, patient and unhurried, tending carefully to the work of becoming something else entirely.

THE END